

The subject indeed is most apt. It is apt because it really depicts what is happening in the world, in our region, and in our respective countries. There is an urgent requirement for change.

Change means breaking the status quo, burying the past, and moving forward positively. I stand for peace. Peace between India and Pakistan for the sake of the whole world, which today considers our region a nuclear flash-point. I stand for peace for the sake of the people of our two countries, for the sake of our future generations to whom we owe a better life and a better environment.

We, the moderates, must guide events. We, the moderates, must stand for resolution of all issues, of all disputes, for everlasting peace and must not allow extremists to create obstacles in the way of that direction towards peace.

I know that the people of Pakistan desire peace. But they would like to have peace with honour and dignity, not a peace through coercion—a peace with sovereign equality.

It was I who initiated the thawing of the relations between India and Pakistan. We began the composite dialogue process. We also started back-channel diplomacy. And then in India there was a change of government—the BJP lost and the Congress took over the reins of the Government. The good thing was despite this change the peace process did not get derailed; it continued and we came for the Delhi summit between me and Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. That was in April 2005. After the Delhi summit, we issued a joint statement which stipulated very importantly that the peace process is irreversible and that purposeful dialogue on Kashmir must be initiated for its final settlement. We also took a lot of other bold steps.

I declared a unilateral ceasefire on the Line of Control (LoC), a unilateral ceasefire which was reciprocated by India and which is still holding out. We have saved so many lives and

so much loss of property. The idea of the Srinagar-Muzaffarabad bus service and the opening up of maybe five more routes for travel across the LoC and a transit trade relationship came from our side. I did this with a very sincere understanding and a very sincere conviction that the path of peace is the right course to be adopted for Pakistan and India and for this whole region and for the whole world.

We have done enough damage to each other since our coming into being. We have fought three wars and we have had a cold war throughout since 1947. I strongly believe that we should try for peace now with equal zeal as we tried confronting each other. The 21st Century is the century of Asia but the question that comes to my mind is if we as South Asians are poised to be a part of this Asian century of progress and development. The answer is no.

While South-east Asia, East Asia, North-east Asia, China and Australia are cooperating for economic development, South Asia and Central Asia are out of the loop. They are out of the loop because of India-Pakistan acrimony and hostility. The three most serious challenges common to both India and Pakistan that we have to face together and separately in our respective countries are—the curse of terrorism and extremism, poverty and underdevelopment, and hostility between our two countries. These are the three issues I think which we have to address and resolve to move forward.

In the few years of rapprochement during my tenure at the helm of affairs in Pakistan, our relations indeed were the best ever. During those years, the trade list of the importable items to Pakistan, I know increased from 200 to 1,400. That benefited both sides. So, therefore, I know bilaterally the trade will increase manifold to our mutual advantage. Intra-regionally there will be so much trade that we stand to gain immeasurably.

Our fight against terrorism and extremism will be more coordinated. With cooperation with each other, we will be able to fight it more strongly. SAARC, the only organisation representing South Asia, will be rejuvenated from all points of views and tourism will boom. But the question that I ask myself is this: is such a dream of peace possible? And the answer is yes. But it is made difficult when we foment hatred within our public, for political expediency and also through a negative media. The key to progress towards peace lies in the affinity of the people of the two countries.

Instead of bringing them closer to each

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PERVEZ MUSHARRAF

